

Meta Ends Third-party Fact-Checking, Adds ‘Community Notes’ System

Facebook parent company Meta recently announced changes to the way it tries to identify misinformation and harmful material published on its social media services.

Meta chief Mark Zuckerberg explained in a video that the company had decided to make the changes because the old system had produced “too many mistakes and too much censorship.”

Issues with Meta moderation

Zuckerberg said the moderation system Meta had built needed to be “complex” to examine huge amounts of content in search of material that violated company policies.

However, he noted the problem with such systems is they can make a lot of errors. The Meta chief added about such systems, “Even if they accidentally censor just one percent of posts, that’s millions of people.”

So, he said the company had decided to move to a new system centered on “reducing mistakes, simplifying our policies, and restoring free expression.”

“Community Notes” system

The new method turns over content moderation duties to a “Community Notes” system. The company said this system aims to “empower the community” to decide whether content is acceptable or needs further examination.

The changes will be effective for Meta’s Facebook, Instagram and Threads services. Meta said the new system would become available first to U.S. users in the coming months.

Meta’s former moderation system involved the use of independent, third-party fact-checking organizations. Many of these were large media companies or news agencies. The efforts included digital tools as well as human workers to fact-check content and identify false, inappropriate or harmful material.

Meta said the third-party moderation method ended up identifying too much information for fact-checking. After closer examination, a lot of content should have been considered “legitimate political speech and debate.”

Another problem, the company said, was that the decisions made by content moderators could be affected by their personal beliefs, opinions and biases. One result was that “a program intended to inform too often became a tool to censor.”

Meta's new Community Notes system is similar to the method used by the social media service X. A statement by Meta said changes to this system will have to be made by users, not anyone from the company.

Meta said, "Just like they do on X, Community Notes will require agreement between people with a range of perspectives to help prevent biased ratings." The company also invited any users to register to be among the first to try out the system.

How did fact-checkers react to Meta's change?

The International Fact-Checking Network (IFCN) criticized Meta's latest decision. It said the move threatened to "undo nearly a decade of progress."

The group rejected Zuckerberg's claim that the fact-checking program had become a "tool to censor" users. It noted, that "the freedom to say why something is not true is also free speech."

Milijana Rogač is executive editor of the Serbian fact-checking outlet Istinomer. She told Reuters news agency that she thinks Meta's decision would end up hurting the media industry. Rogač noted that research suggests that many citizens use Meta services as their main source for information. Removing independent fact-checkers "further hinders access to accurate information and news," Rogač said.

How effective are Community Notes?

Not a lot of research has been done on how effective Community Notes systems are. But one effort carried out by the University of California and Johns Hopkins University found in 2024 that community notes entered on X for COVID-19 misinformation were accurate. The research showed the notes used both moderate and high-quality sources and were attached to widely read posts.

However, the number of people taking part in that study was small. Also, the effects the system had on users' opinions and behavior is unknown.

A 2023 study, from the Journal of Online Trust and Safety, said it was harder for users to agree when they examined content related to political issues.

I'm Bryan Lynn.

Bryan Lynn wrote this story, based on reports from Meta, The Associated Press and Reuters.

Quiz - Meta Ends Third-party Fact-Checking, Adds 'Community Notes' System

Vocabulary

censorship - n. ระบบหรือการปฏิบัติในการตรวจสอบหรือควบคุมข้อมูลในหนังสือ ภาพยนตร์ อินเทอร์เน็ต เป็นต้น

moderate - v. ควบคุมดูแล (เพื่อให้แน่ใจว่ากฎของการสนทนาทางอินเทอร์เน็ตไม่ถูกละเมิด)

content - n. เนื้อหา (เช่น งานเขียน เสียง หรือภาพที่พบทางออนไลน์)

inappropriate - adj. ไม่เหมาะสม (สิ่งที่ผิดหรือไม่ถูกต้องในสถานการณ์หนึ่งและขึ้นอยู่กับความคิดเห็นของผู้คน)

legitimate - adj. ถูกต้องตามกฎหมาย; แท้จริง; ชอบธรรม

bias - n. อคติ (สถานการณ์ที่คุณสนับสนุนหรือต่อต้านบางสิ่งอย่างไม่ยุติธรรมเพราะได้รับอิทธิพลจากความคิดเห็นส่วนตัว)

range - n. ขอบเขต; ช่วง; ความหลากหลาย (องค์ประกอบทั้งหมดของชุดของวัตถุหรือตัวเลข)

perspective - n. มุมมอง; ทศนคติ (วิธีที่บุคคลคิดเกี่ยวกับบางสิ่ง)

decade - n. ทศวรรษ (ช่วงเวลา 10 ปี)

hinder - v. ขัดขวาง; เป็นอุปสรรค (ทำให้ยากที่จะทำบางสิ่งบางอย่าง)

accurate - adj. ถูกต้อง; แม่นยำ (เป็นจริงหรือถูกต้อง)

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What significant change did Meta, the parent company of Facebook, recently announce?

- A) A new investment in virtual reality technology.
- B) Changes to how it identifies misinformation and harmful material.
- C) The acquisition of a new social media platform.
- D) A reduction in its global workforce.

2. According to Mark Zuckerberg, what was the primary reason for Meta's decision to change its old moderation system?

- A) The system was too slow to react to new trends.
- B) It was too expensive to maintain.
- C) The old system produced too many mistakes and too much censorship.
- D) Users demanded a more lenient moderation policy.

3. What characteristic did Mark Zuckerberg say Meta's old moderation system needed to possess to handle vast amounts of content?

- A) Transparency
- B) Simplicity
- C) Adaptability
- D) Complexity

4. What specific problem did Mark Zuckerberg highlight regarding complex moderation systems, even if errors are statistically small?

- A) They are difficult for users to understand.
- B) They consume too much processing power.
- C) Even small error rates can affect millions of people.
- D) They are prone to political manipulation.

5. What are the main goals of Meta's new system, as stated by Mark Zuckerberg?

- A) Increasing user engagement and advertising revenue.
- B) Expanding into new global markets.
- C) Reducing mistakes, simplifying policies, and restoring free expression.
- D) Enhancing data security and privacy features.

6. What is the core function of the new 'Community Notes' system?

- A) To automatically filter all offensive content.
- B) To empower the community to decide content acceptability.
- C) To provide educational resources to users.
- D) To identify and remove bots from the platforms.

7. Which Meta services will implement the new content moderation changes?

- A) WhatsApp, Messenger, and Oculus.
- B) Facebook, Instagram, and Threads.
- C) Workplace, Portal, and Novi.
- D) All Meta platforms globally at once.

8. Who was primarily responsible for fact-checking under Meta's former moderation system?

- A) Meta's internal legal department.
- B) Independent, third-party fact-checking organizations.
- C) Government regulatory bodies.
- D) Artificial intelligence algorithms exclusively.

9. According to Meta, what was a key issue with the former third-party moderation method regarding content identification?

- A) It was too slow to process content.
- B) It failed to identify truly harmful material.
- C) It identified too much information for fact-checking, including legitimate political speech.

D) It was too expensive to operate efficiently.

10. What other significant problem did Meta identify with the previous content moderation system, besides over-identification?

A) Lack of language support for global users.

B) The decisions of moderators could be influenced by personal beliefs and biases.

C) Frequent system crashes and downtime.

D) Inability to integrate with new technological advancements.

11. The new Community Notes system is compared to a method used by which other social media service?

A) TikTok

B) LinkedIn

C) YouTube

D) X

12. How does Meta intend to prevent biased ratings within its new Community Notes system?

A) By limiting participation to professional journalists.

B) By using AI to automatically correct biases.

C) By requiring agreement between people with a range of perspectives.

D) By allowing only anonymous contributions.

13. How did the International Fact-Checking Network (IFCN) react to Meta's latest decision regarding content moderation?

A) They fully supported the move, calling it innovative.

B) They expressed neutrality, awaiting further data.

C) They criticized it, stating it threatened to 'undo nearly a decade of progress.'

D) They offered to collaborate on the new system.

14. What was the IFCN's counter-argument to Zuckerberg's claim that the fact-checking program became a 'tool to censor'?

A) They stated that fact-checking is a necessary evil.

B) They argued that 'the freedom to say why something is not true is also free speech.'

C) They claimed Zuckerberg misunderstood the program's purpose.

D) They presented data showing no censorship occurred.

15. According to Milijana Rogač, what negative impact will Meta's decision have, especially concerning access to information?

- A) It will increase the spread of foreign propaganda.
- B) It will reduce the profitability of Meta's platforms.
- C) It will hurt the media industry and hinder access to accurate information and news.
- D) It will lead to an exodus of users to other platforms.